Pursuit of Happiness and When the Bough Breaks

By Andrea Gibson

INTRODUCTION

March 20, 2003 *– President George Bush announced the beginning of the war in Iraq.*
December 18, 2011 *– President Barak Obama announced the end of the war and removed the last US troops.*

At one time the US had more than 160,000 troops in Iraq and another 100,00 in Afghanistan. But the military pulled out of Afghanistan completely in 2021 and today operations in the Middle East are limited.

Andrea Gibson in her poem "The Pursuit of Happiness" questions American involvement in the Middle East.

ICATIONAL

Pursuit of Happiness (Pg 88-90)

Tonight in Iraq, there is a race to rape little girls before they can be raped by U.S. soldiers
Tonight in Iran, there is a missile aimed at the hill where Hafiz cut pieces of his soul with a knife and wove them into a blanket to protect us
Tonight, my skin is the color of a hundred white flags

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torn apart at the seams and sewn together into the body bag that holds her only son
And I am told God's will is done

By hands that pan for gold in the bloodstreams of children while a million souls are sold on the slave blocks of a pipeline
and a mother turns her bones into a bunker
fills her lungs with sand and cradles her baby daughter until her own clavicle is blown to powder fine as the dust on a butterfly's wing

But tonight there are no flowers
Every flashing red light is a heart threatening to quit
The moon is a tourniquet we will bleed through by morning
Is this your pursuit of happiness?

The casket as small as a music box
A mother holding that song to her ear
America, I dare to rest your holy water beside her tears and see where Jesus chooses to walk
Heaven doesn't know your name
Only the sound of you rolling your barrels of blood to its

gates
thinking grace is something you can buy with Mohammed's pulse

Tell me again how you intend to rescue their women
How you will teach them how to read in the schools you have turned to prisons
How you will offer them doctors in the hospitals you have burned with their children inside
Tell me how they won't have to hide beneath their burkas
How you will wrap them in lace 'til they are all as conveniently rapeable as women in the States
Do you know how much desert sand is on the floor of the women's shelter in this city?
Have you ever tried to blink the light back?
Do you know the man who beat her had been ordered to fit five Afghani children in a single body bag
Is this your pursuit of happiness?

The orphanage you lit like a cigarette
You cough and it sounds like screams
You cancel the soul with your holy flag
You dog-tagged your son,

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Choke-chained his two years into eight,
and forgot his name when you couldn't afford the gas to drive to his funeral
Do you know how his family loved you?
Their trust was an orchard
Now tonight at their table nothing is alive but his empty chair
If you are a nation under God, how is hell so close to your prayers?

Do you see what you are pressing against your bones?
Bones cannot break
Into song
A mother can never find the right place to store an empty cradle
A mouth can never find the right shape to hold the lullabies it will never sing
America, if you could rip the pipelines from your throat,
if you could hang them like wind chimes from the battered night
would you remember how freedom rings?
Would you remember that every river is a lantern running

without oil

and your children sing your anthems so proud

America

The beautiful

Remember

Where you melted the desert, the sand became a mirror

If you could stand so close the flames caught the lashes of your eyes

If you could memorize one face fading into smoke and never ever forget

If you could let one more soldier write his blood type on his boots

Would you let your pursuit of happiness steal so much God from the heart that I know is still pounding beneath your bloody hands?

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TRANSITION

Let's be honest for a moment. The average American is more concerned with when the new season of their favorite show is going to start or the release date of the next block-buster movie than they are about world events.

Sure, we see news reports about the Middle East, North Korea, Africa, Ukraine – but those places are half a world away. Sure, we know that in the U.S. there's an immigration problem, an unemployment problem, a prison overpopulation problem, but they don't really affect the average American, right? It's just more drama at best and at worst – "fake news."

But what if . . . what if all this DOES affect the average American. What if it is the insidious catalyst behind our rising discontent? What if we are forced to wake up from our American dream and face a reality that we simply cannot comprehend?

When the Bough Breaks by Andrea Gibson

When the Bough Breaks (Pg 73-76)

It's two a.m.

The emergency room psychiatrist looks up from his clipboard

with eyes paid to care

and asks me if I see people who aren't really there.

I say, “I see people
how the hell am I supposed to know
if they’re really there or not?”
He doesn’t laugh
neither do I.
The math’s not on my side
ten stitches and one lie.
I swear I wasn’t trying to die.
I just wanted to see what my pulse looked like from the inside.

Fast forward one year.
I’m standing in an auditorium behind a microphone
reading a poem to four hundred Latino high school kids
who live with the breath of the INS
crawling up their mother’s backbones
and I am frantically hiding my scars
‘cause the last thing I want these kids to know
is that I ever thought that my life was too hard.

I’ve never seen a bomb drop.
I’ve never felt hunger.
I’ve also never seen lightning strike

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but we’ve all heard thunder
and it doesn’t take a genius to tell something’s burning.
The smoke rises between us,
forming walls so high
they split the sky like slit wrists
and then the stars fall like blood.
We’re all left with nothing, but a death wish.

He said, “Call me by my true name
I am the child in Uganda all skin and bone”
Do you remember the rest?
how about this one, America
Jesus wept.
America, Jesus wept
but look at your eyes
dry as the desert sand
dusting the edges of your soldier’s wedding bands.
Look at your soul playing dead
because your ribcage is Abu Ghraib
is San Quintin
is Guantanamo Bay

and your heart had beaten them so many times
they bleed the moon.

Do you know children in Palestine fly kites to prove that
they are still free?
Can you imagine how that string must feel between their
fingers
as they kneel in the cinders of our missile heads
You can count the dead by the colors in the sky

The bough is breaking.
The cradle is falling.
Right now a six-year old girl is crouched in a ditch in
Lebanon
wishing on falling bombs.
Right now our government is recording the test scores of
black and Latino 4th graders
to see how many prison beds will be needed in the year
2021.
Right now there's a man on the street outside that door
with outstretched hands full of heartbeats no one can hear.
He has cheeks like torn sheet music,
Every tear a broken crescendo falling on closed ears.

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At his side there's a girl with eyes like an anthem
that no one stands up for.

Doctor, our insanity is not that we see people who aren't
there.
It's that we ignore the ones who are.
Till we find ourselves scarred and ashamed
walking into emergency rooms at three a.m.
flooded with a pain we cannot name or explain
because we are bleeding from the outside in.
Skin is not impervious.
Cultures built on greed and destruction do not pick and
choose who they kill.

Do we really believe our need for Prozac
has nothing to do with Baghdad,
with Kabul, with the Mexican border
with the thousands of US school kids
bleeding through budget cuts that will never heal
to fuel war tanks?

Thank god for denial.
Thank god we can afford the makeup

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to pile upon the face of it all.

Look at the pretty world.

Look at all the smiling people

and the sky with a missile between her teeth

and a steeple through her heart

and not a single star left to hold her

And the voices of a thousand broken nations saying

“Wake me, wake me, when the American dream is over”

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